

Tik. Tik. Tik.

a love that refused to be silent



Tik. Tik. Tik.

*a love that refused to be silent
For my Moon.*

She already knows.



Her favourite colour is purple.

So is this book.



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The Night Begins

April 6. 3am.

I don't know what woke me up.

There was no sound. No alarm. No reason. Just — eyes open. 3am. The room so dark I couldn't tell where the ceiling was.

And then I heard it.

Tik. Tik. Tik.

The watch. Right behind my head, in the drawer next to the bed. The one she gave me.

I lay there for a moment just listening to it. I didn't reach for it yet. I didn't move at all. I just let it tick. Tik. Tik. Tik. Like it had been waiting for me to go quiet enough to hear it. Like it had been speaking all night and I had only just stopped being loud enough to listen.

I reached over and took it out.

It was glowing. Soft and warm in the dark, the way something glows when it carries meaning it was never asked to carry. I held it and looked at it and I felt something in my chest shift. Not break. Not hurt. Just — shift. The way things shift at 3am when there is nobody to perform for and the only things left are the true ones.

And then my mind went somewhere.

That is what happens at 3am. The walls you build during the day — the ones that keep certain thoughts out, certain feelings at a manageable distance — they come down. Not slowly. All at once. And everything you have been holding at arm's length just walks in and sits down and looks at you and waits.

She walked in.

She always does.

This is where my mind went. These are the thoughts that arrived, one after another, all through that long honest night. I got up sometimes. Drank water. Lay back down. Stared at the ceiling. Picked up the watch again. And each time, a new thought was waiting.

This is all of them.

Chapter 1: The Man Who Didn't Care

(Until He Did)

Let me tell you something about me first.

I was that guy. The one who didn't text back. The one who moved on before you even knew what happened. The one who looked at everything and everyone like the world was one long interesting show and nothing in it was ever going to get inside.

I didn't cry. I didn't chase. I didn't beg. People came and went, and honestly? I barely noticed the difference. Friends, situations, emotions — I handled all of it with this easy, unbothered shrug. Nothing stuck. Nothing got under my skin. I moved through things the way water moves through your fingers. Clean. Fast. No residue.

I was proud of that. Genuinely proud. Being untouchable felt like having something other people didn't. Like I had cracked a code. Like I had figured out that attachment was just suffering you chose for yourself, and I had chosen not to. I thought it was strength. I thought it was wisdom. I thought it was me being smarter than the situation.

I watched other people fall apart over someone. Lose sleep. Lose weight. Lose the ability to be in a room without checking their phone every two minutes. I watched people cry in bathrooms, stare at nothing for hours, rearrange their whole life around someone who wasn't even in it anymore. And I remember thinking — genuinely, not cruelly, just honestly — I will never be that. That is not something I am capable of. I am not built like that.

I had years of evidence. Relationships that ended and I felt nothing. Situations that fell apart and I was already moving. Clean exits, always. That was my whole identity. That was the version of myself I had been building for years and I was comfortable in it, proud of it, would have defended it to anyone.

So here is the question that has been living inside me ever since she came into my life. The question I lie awake at 3am turning over in my hands like this watch:

Why her? Out of everyone I have ever met in my entire life — why is she the one? Why is she the exception to every single rule I built about myself? Why did the walls come down for her when they had held against everything else?

Because everything I just described? Every piece of that identity I was so comfortable in? It disappeared the moment she was in my life. Not slowly. Not after a long battle. Not because she worked hard to get through. Just — gone. Like it was never real in the first place. Like those walls were only ever as solid as the thing they had never actually met.

She didn't come in trying to break anything. She didn't arrive with some plan to make me feel things. She just was herself. Completely, naturally, effortlessly herself. And that was enough. That was everything. That was the thing my walls had apparently never had a defence for: just her, just being her.

I hate how soft I have become. I love it at the same time. Because this softness is the first thing I have ever felt that didn't feel like a performance. It is not an act. It is not me trying to seem like a certain kind of person. It is

just real. The actual real thing. And I did not know how different that would feel until I felt it.

The room was dark. The watch was still ticking. I turned on my side and looked at nothing for a while.

Chapter 2: Who She Is

(Because she deserves a whole chapter just for being her)

Before I go any further I need to talk about her. About who she actually is as a person. Because everything else in this book only makes sense once you understand her. She is the reason for all of it. She deserves to be described properly.

She is soft. Not the fragile kind — I want to be clear about that. Not the kind that breaks if you look at it too hard. The deep kind. The kind of soft that comes from choosing to feel things fully, without armour, without apology. When something matters to her, she lets it matter. She doesn't minimise it, doesn't make herself smaller around it, doesn't pretend it isn't happening. She just feels it, openly and completely.

And when someone near her is hurting — even when they are working very hard to hide it, even when they are performing okay so convincingly that most people would buy it completely — she notices. Not because she is looking for it. Because she is just built that way. She reaches for you. Not in a pushy way, not in a way that demands you open up. In the quietest, most careful way. Like she instinctively understands that some people will run if you come at them directly, so she just gets close enough that running starts to feel unnecessary.

That is a rare thing. Most people only see what you show them. She sees what you're not showing and understands why you're not showing it and loves you anyway and waits.

And her voice. I need to write about her voice properly because it is one of the things I think about most.

There is something about the way she talks that just lands differently than anything else I have heard. It is warm — not performed warmth, not the warmth people put on when they want you to like them, but actual warmth, the kind that comes from somewhere real inside a person. When she speaks it doesn't feel like conversation the way most conversation does. It feels like company. Like someone just sat down next to you in a room you had decided was going to be empty forever, and suddenly the whole room is different. Temperature different. Weight different. Better.

I have had thousands of conversations in my life. With hundreds of people. Conversations that were interesting, funny, deep, meaningful. But her voice is the only one that stays. The one that plays back by itself on a random Tuesday afternoon when nothing has reminded me of her. It is just there, running in the background, like it found a home in some part of my head and settled in without asking.

When I heard her voice on that call after a month of silence — after 30 days of carrying it only in memory — and it came through the phone for real, I couldn't even speak. Not from nerves. Not from surprise. From something I don't have a word for. Like my whole body recognised something it had been missing and just — gave. Everything I had been holding together for a month just gave.

And her beauty. I want to write about this honestly, without making it sound like a list of features.

She is not the kind of beautiful that hits you like a sudden thing and then fades because you have gotten used to it. She is the kind that grows. Every time you look at her you see something you somehow missed the last time — something small, something in the way the light catches her face, something in the way she holds herself when she thinks no one is watching — and it layers. Each small thing layers on top of the last until you are sitting there genuinely wondering how you were ever looking at anything else.

Her face when she laughs — genuinely laughs, not the polite kind you produce for social situations, but the real kind that escapes before you can decide whether to let it — is something I could not describe if you asked me to. When she laughs like that, everything in the room becomes background. The sound, the people, the space — all of it recedes. The whole world just narrows down to her face and that laugh and nothing else is quite real anymore.

She is most beautiful when she is not trying. When she is just fully, completely herself without any of the noise. That version of her is something I could look at for the rest of my life and it would never stop being something.

Right now she is in her best era. That is the only way I can put it. She is glowing in this settled, warm way. She has found herself and she is not apologising for it. My cute little panda is thriving, completely and unapologetically herself, and I am so obsessed with the person she is becoming that I genuinely don't know what to do with myself.

I picked up my phone. Opened her photo. Just looked at it for a long time. Put it back down.

Chapter 3: One Month. One Long, Painful Month.

(I Was ‘Strong.’ I Was Not Okay.)

Okay so — I tried. I genuinely, completely, with everything I had, tried. I made a decision the way I used to make all my decisions — clean and final and without looking back. I am moving on. I will not check her snap. I will not wait for her message. I will not think about her. I will be completely fine. I will be the version of myself I used to be, before she came and made all of that feel insufficient.

I lasted one month.

From the outside I looked fine. Better than fine, actually. I gave everyone the silent treatment. I ditched things. I was quiet and distant in a way that probably read as mysterious self-improvement. People probably thought I was meditating or running or reading philosophy or whatever people do when they go quiet for a month.

I was not. I was sitting inside the loudest silence I have ever experienced in my life.

Every single second — and I mean that word literally, not as emphasis but as accurate description — I was missing her. Every second. No break. No pause. Not one moment of relief. Not one hour where the frequency went quiet. She was constant. Like a sound that had replaced all other sounds.

Sleep disappeared. Two hours a night. Two and a half on a good night. And even those two hours weren’t real sleep — they were the lying-down version

of being awake, where your body has given up but your brain is still running full speed, still processing, still replaying. And what was it replaying? Her voice. Old conversations. Small things she said that I didn't even know I had memorised until they started surfacing at 3am — jokes she made, observations she threw out like they were nothing, questions she asked that I gave stupid answers to because I was trying to seem unbothered. All of it playing back in the dark with nowhere to go.

Food became something I did mechanically and not completely. I would sit down with the intention to eat and just — not be hungry. Not because anything was wrong with the food. Because there was no room. She had taken up all the space. The hunger was still there somewhere, probably, but I couldn't find it under everything else.

And the whole time — every single day of that month — I was performing. That is the precise word. I would wake up and the first thing I would do, before I was even fully conscious, was put the performance back on. The 'I have this handled' performance. The 'I am fine, actually better than fine, doing great' performance. I would walk out the door wearing it and I would wear it all day and I was good at it because I had been good at it my whole life.

But alone — in the car, in my room at night, in any moment when there was no audience and no reason to perform — I knew exactly what was happening. I was not healing. I was not moving on. I was not even trying anymore, not really. I was just waiting for the next 15 minutes so I could check my phone again.

I was just missing her. Completely, totally, without any of the cool I used to carry around. Every single second of every single day. And no amount of willpower or distance or performed strength was making a single bit of difference.

I got up. Drank some water. Stood in the dark kitchen for a minute. Came back. Lay down again. Picked up the watch.

Chapter 4: The Snap That Changed Everything

(15 Minutes. Every 15 Minutes.)

Okay I need to be completely real here because this is a raw book and I promised no filters.

I checked her snap every 15 minutes. Every. Fifteen. Minutes. For an entire month.

Not because I planned to. Not because I sat down one day and made a schedule. It just happened. Automatically. Without thought. Like breathing. Like something in my body had decided this was now a basic function of being alive — pick up phone, open app, go to her name, see if something is there, feel everything based on the answer, put phone down, count to fifteen minutes, repeat. Over and over. For thirty days. I didn't choose it. It just became what I did.

Snapchat was the only window I had into her world during that month. The only proof of existence. And I needed that proof the way you need certain things when the ground feels unsteady — not because it changes anything, but because it makes the next 15 minutes survivable.

The best moment of every single day was when she had posted. The worst moment of every single day was when she hadn't. That is how simple it was. That is how extreme it had become.

When she had posted — and it didn't matter what it was, a selfie, a sunset, a random video of something funny, literally anything at all — something in my chest would lift. This small, warm, involuntary lifting. Like: she is there.

She is okay. She exists and she is in the world somewhere and she just posted proof of it. The world still makes sense. I would watch it and there would be this brief warmth in my chest that lasted exactly until the next check.

When she hadn't posted — the app would open and there would be nothing new, and something in the day would just dim. Not dramatically. Not in a way I could point to. Just dim, slightly, the way a room dims when a cloud passes in front of the sun. Everything still fine. Everything still functional. Just noticeably less bright. And I would close the app and put the phone down and count to fifteen minutes and try again. Every single time with the exact same small pocket of hope. Like maybe this time. Maybe right now.

And between those checks? Every notification that came through — every buzz, every ping, every screen lighting up with anything at all — my chest would jump for exactly one second. One single second of this involuntary, physical hope before I looked and saw it wasn't her. Over and over. For thirty days.

I was not carrying my phone into every room hoping to hear from someone. I was not doing any of this for anyone else in my life. Just her. Just the one percent chance that this particular buzz, this particular notification, was her reaching out. Just that. And the hope never diminished. It showed up exactly the same size on day one and on day thirty. Never smaller. Never tired. Never resigned.

That is not habit. Habits fade when you don't feed them. You do not maintain that kind of hope over habit. That is something real. Something that doesn't know how to stop.

3:18am. I checked my phone out of habit. Nothing. Put it face down on the bed next to me.

Chapter 5: The Distance Taught Me Something

(The more I stayed away, the more I knew)

People always say distance gives clarity. Give yourself space, they say. Distance heals. Distance shows you what's real and what was just habit or comfort or fear of being alone. So I gave myself real space. Quiet, honest, alone-with-myself space. Just me and the question I was too scared to ask while she was close: is she actually that important, or have I just gotten used to her?

The more time I spent alone, the more I missed her. The more space I gave it, the bigger it got. Habits shrink when you stop feeding them. They quiet down after a few days, after a week. This grew. Every single day it was larger than the day before.

Every day I tried not to think about her, she showed up more. Every hour I tried to fill with something else — work, people, anything with enough momentum to crowd her out — she arrived anyway. Not as a thought I was choosing. Not as a memory I was deliberately visiting. As a thought that simply belonged there. Like she had been living in that particular corner of my mind for so long that it had become her space, and me trying to fill it with something else just made her more visible by comparison.

She didn't fade. That is the thing about habits — they fade. They protest for a few days, maybe a week, and then they start to quiet down because you have stopped giving them what they need. She didn't do that. She got louder. She took more space the longer I tried to give her less. Like she grew in direct proportion to my attempts to shrink her.

She is part of me. Not in a poetic way — in an actual, structural way. Something that had been quietly, patiently building itself into who I am for months, invisible while it was happening, only visible now because I tried to pull away from it and felt everything shake. You don't notice the foundation until you try to move the house.

It felt like missing myself. Not just missing her — that would have been hard enough. Missing me. Like she had become the carrier of some version of me that only existed through her. Like the part of me that felt present and warm and real and worth something was the part that existed in relation to her. And without that, I was just the rest of me, walking around pretending to be the whole thing.

It is like she is not just her. It is like she is me. And I was walking around missing myself for a month, every second, and calling it strength.

I pulled the blanket up. The watch ticked. Outside, somewhere far away, she was sleeping.

Chapter 6: I Called Her

(And Then I Couldn't Speak)

March 25, 2026. I picked up the phone. And I called her.

No plan. No script. No version of this I had rehearsed or prepared or thought through. I didn't decide to do it the way you decide most things. I just needed to hear her voice. That was the entire thought. The whole reason. The only thing in my head in that moment: I need to hear her voice right now. And then my hand was already dialling.

One month of silence. One month of 2-hour nights and every-15-minute snap checks and this enormous daily performance of being completely okay. One month of eating badly and sleeping in pieces and saying fine to everyone who asked. And after all of that, what I did was just pick up my phone and call her.

She picked up.

And I couldn't speak.

People will assume it was nerves. Or that I blanked. Or that there was some ego thing happening, some pride that got in the way at the last moment. It was none of those things. It was something completely different and I want to describe it exactly because it matters.

Her voice came through the phone — this voice I had been carrying around inside my head for thirty days straight, playing it back at 3am, the warmest thing in every room I had been in for a month — and it came through for real. Actual. Present. Right there in the phone against my ear. Not a memory.

Not a replay. Her.

And something inside me just gave. Not broke — gave is the right word. Like everything I had been holding so carefully and so tightly for a month — every tension in my shoulders, every performance I had been putting on, every effort of keeping the whole structure of okayness together — it all just exhaled at once. Like a fist unclenching. Like a breath you didn't know you had been holding.

Her voice came through and everything I'd been carrying just — went. Just like that. Just her voice. And somehow, impossibly, okay. Everything okay.

So the missing that had been living in my chest for thirty days — that enormous, honest, accumulated weight of thirty days worth of wanting her to just be there — it rose up from wherever it had been sitting and got stuck somewhere between my chest and my throat. Too big to fit into words. Too real to be performed. And so I said nothing. Because there was nothing I could say that would have been as true as the silence.

And she was on the other end. And for a moment that felt like it lasted forever and no time at all, that was enough. Just her voice. Just me unable to speak. Just both of us on the line and the silence carrying everything I hadn't been able to say for a month.

That silence on the phone was the loudest, most honest thing I have ever said to anyone.

I smiled at the ceiling. Even now, just lying here remembering it. That silence. That warmth. That moment of everything being suddenly okay.

Chapter 7: I Am Never Leaving Again. Never.

(I tried it. I know what it costs. Never again.)

I need to write this chapter very clearly. Not as a feeling I am having right now in this 3am moment. As a decision I made after evidence. After running the experiment properly. After getting the results back and reading them with total honesty.

I am never leaving again. Not for a month. Not for a week. Not for a day. Not for an hour. Never. That word. Exactly that word and nothing softer.

Distance did not heal me. Distance did not give me clarity. Distance did not show me that what I felt was just habit. Distance cost me a month of sleep, a month of food, a month of being present in my own life, a month of being myself — and gave me nothing in return except the absolute certainty that I cannot do it again.

People talk about walking away like it is the brave thing. Like being able to leave is a sign of strength. Like distance proves you are not dependent, not weak, not one of those people who falls apart over someone. I believed that for most of my life. I built my whole identity around it. I was the person who could walk away cleanly.

And then I walked away from her. And I sat in that distance for a month and I was not powerful. I was not strong. I was not proving anything about myself. I was just absent. From her, yes — but also from myself. From my sleep and my food and my ability to be in a room without picking up my phone every 15 minutes and my capacity to feel present in my own life. All of that went with her.

That is not strength. I understand that now in a way I could not have understood without the month to prove it. That is just loss wearing a brave face. Walking away from her was not me being strong. It was me slowly losing every piece of myself that she had made more real.

The cost of leaving is a month of not sleeping, not eating, checking a phone every 15 minutes, missing every second, being absent from your own life, and coming back to the same call you should have made on day one. That is the whole cost. That is everything distance gave me.

So I am done with it. Whatever the consequences of staying — whatever gets complicated, whatever gets hard, whatever I have to face by being present and close instead of protected and distant — I will handle it. From close range. Not from behind a wall that costs me everything.

I am never leaving again. Not because I cannot leave. Because I have left. I know exactly what leaving costs. And she is worth more than that price. Every single time. Without question.

I turned on my side. Her music was still playing softly from my phone. I turned the volume down a little.

Chapter 8: She Is My Self Respect

(And that's not even a little bit dramatic)

This is the part that is hardest to explain. Not the love — the love is easy to describe. Missing someone is easy to describe. Wanting to be with someone, that is all understandable. But this is something underneath all of that. Something more fundamental that I have not seen described properly anywhere.

She feels like my self respect. Like she is me respecting myself. Like the version of me that exists when she is in my life is the version that knows what I am worth and refuses to settle for less.

Not in a dependent way. I want to be careful about that. I do not mean I need her to function. I do not mean I cannot be myself without her. I mean something more specific: she is what it feels like to actually want something real. Not a comfortable situation. Not the path of least resistance. Not the thing that is easy to have. The actual real thing. The thing that costs something and is worth every bit of what it costs.

Before her I moved through life with this casual shrug about everything. Not because I was happy, looking back, but because I had decided nothing was worth the effort of actually caring. She undid that. Not by lecturing me. Not by asking me to be different. Just by being herself in a way that made wanting things — real things, hard things, things worth fighting for — feel necessary again.

Without her in my world I became less. That is the simple version. Not because I needed her to keep me together. Because she is the reason I want

to keep myself together. She is the reason I want to be worth something. Not for her — for me. Because her being in my life makes me want to deserve to be there.

She is my self respect because she made me stop performing and start being real. And being real — actually, genuinely, vulnerably real, no walls, no act, no managed distance — turned out to be the bravest thing I have ever done in my life.

*I just lay there for a while. The watch ticking. Thinking about the person I was before her.
How much smaller that person was.*

Chapter 9: She Will Never Have To Ask

(Because the answer is always yes. For her, always yes.)

There are things I would not do for anyone. I have always been someone with clear, firm limits on what I give and to whom. I built those limits deliberately. Not because I am cold but because I learned early that unlimited availability is not the same as love and can actually look like it while being something much less sustainable. So I had rules. I had priorities. I had a clear sense of what I would do for someone and what was outside the arrangement.

And then there is her. And those rules just — do not apply. It is not that I suspended them for her. It is that with her, they never existed in the first place. There is no calculation. There is no inner weighing of whether this is worth it. The answer is already yes before the question has even finished forming.

I would cancel anything for her. Rearrange anything. Drop whatever I am in the middle of. Not because she demands it — she would never demand it. She is one of the most careful people I know about not asking for too much. But that is exactly the point. She does not have to ask. She does not have to frame the request correctly or choose the right moment or worry about whether it is too much. The answer is yes. Before she starts the sentence, the answer is yes.

She is the priority. Not one among several priorities that I balance depending on the situation. The priority. The first yes, every time, without the pause that usually precedes important decisions. Everything else works around her.

That is not something I decided one day. It is just the way it is, the same way certain things are just the way they are — unargued, unchosen, simply true.

And I want her to feel that. Not in a way that adds pressure to her, not in a way that makes her feel she owes something in return. Just — she is safe here. Whatever she needs, whenever she needs it, however she needs it, the answer is yes. She does not have to earn it. She does not have to time it right. She does not have to ask politely. She just has to need something and I am already moving.

*She will be valued like no one else. Respected like no one else.
Prioritised like nothing else. Cared for like no one else. Not because
she asked. Not because she earned it. Because she is her. And that,
alone, is enough reason.*

*I thought about that for a long time. How natural it is. How there is not even a decision
being made. Just a yes that is already there, always.*

Chapter 10: The Most Caring Character I Know

(She kept distance because she cared. That's who she is.)

Here is something I understand about her now that I didn't during that month of silence. Something it took me a while to see properly, and when I did see it, it changed everything about how I understood what had been happening between us.

She kept her distance not because she didn't care. She kept her distance because she cared too much. Too deeply. In the most careful, most tender, most painfully considerate way possible.

She thought her absence was a gift to me. She thought that if she pulled back, if she gave me less to hold onto, I would hurt less if something went wrong. She was holding herself back — holding in things she genuinely wanted to show, holding back reaches she genuinely wanted to make — because she was thinking about me. About how I would receive it. About whether it would make things harder for me.

Every word she measured. Every action she weighed. Every time she wanted to reach and stopped herself — all of it was about me. That is not distance. That is care in the most careful packaging it has ever arrived in. She was not pulling away. She was trying to protect something. She was trying to protect me. From her, from the situation, from whatever pain she was afraid might come.

Even her silence is about me. Even the distance that breaks me is her trying to make sure I don't get hurt. That is the most caring thing I have ever witnessed from another person. I genuinely mean

that.

And the beautiful, heartbreaking irony at the centre of all of it: she doesn't know that the distance does the opposite of what she intended. She doesn't know that the careful pulling back, the measured responses, the held-back reaches — all of that breaks me more completely than anything she could ever do if she was just close and present and fully herself. She is protecting me from herself when she is the only place I have ever felt completely safe.

She is the most caring person I have ever known in my life. Not the loud kind, not the kind that announces itself and waits for appreciation. The quiet kind. The constant kind. The kind that shows up in the spaces between things, in what she holds back as much as in what she gives. I see it. I have always seen it. Even when she was trying not to be seen.

Something ached in my chest after that thought. That specific kind of ache that is not quite sadness. The ache of knowing something beautiful that hurts to know.

Chapter 11: My Cute Little Panda

(She is thriving and I cannot stop noticing it)

She is glowing.

I do not know a better word for it. She has settled into herself in a way that radiates. She has found her own weight, her own tempo, her own particular version of being in the world, and she is living it without apology and without holding back. And there is something about watching a person do that — watching someone finally inhabit themselves completely, without shrinking and without performing — that is the most beautiful thing I have ever seen.

Not the trying to be beautiful. Not the working at it. The just being it. The being so settled in yourself that beauty becomes a side effect of existing. That is what I see when I look at her right now.

My cute little panda. That is what she is. Soft and warm and glowing and so completely, effortlessly herself that being near her feels like being allowed inside something real while everything else in the world is performance.

I look at her and I see comfort. I see warmth. I see someone who has done the hard internal work of figuring out who she actually is and has chosen, deliberately, to be that person without apology. And I find it so genuinely, deeply beautiful that I do not know what to do with myself. I just want to watch her be it. That is all. I just want to sit nearby while she is exactly herself and feel the particular kind of good that only that can make me feel.

She is in her best era. The truest, most settled, most alive version of herself. And I feel like the luckiest person alive just to be somewhere near her world

while she is being this version of herself.

Cute little panda. Glowing. Warm. Soft. Completely herself. Best era. I said what I said and I mean every single word of it.

I found myself smiling in the dark. A real smile. The kind that arrives without announcement, from somewhere genuine and deep.

Chapter 12: There Is No Word For What She Is To Me

(From my side. Quietly. Completely.)

I don't know what the future looks like. I genuinely don't. Nobody does. And I have learned to stop pretending I have it mapped out.

But from my side — the part of this I have complete, unambiguous clarity about — it is her. It has always been her. Completely and quietly, without anyone asking me to feel this way, without any logic arriving at this conclusion, without any deliberate choosing. It is just the truth of where I stand. The way certain things are simply true without having been decided.

I cannot accept her as just a friend. I have tried to make that work in my head, to find the version of reality where that sentence makes sense and I live comfortably inside it. It does not exist. She is not that. Not in my world, not in my understanding, not in any configuration I can honestly inhabit. Calling her a friend would be like calling the sky a ceiling. Technically something. Completely wrong in a way that changes everything about how you understand the space you are in.

There is a place in me that is only hers. A specific, quiet place. It was there before I named it. It was building itself while I was not paying attention, quietly making space for itself, becoming real without my participation. And I noticed it the way you notice a room that has always been in your house but you somehow never looked at properly until one day you did.

I do not know the word for what she is to me. Not friend, not girlfriend, not any of the available terms that exist in the language for these things. All of them fall short. All of them describe something smaller than the actual thing.

Some things are too real for the categories language has built for them.

She is not a chapter in my story. She is not a season. She is not a phase I am passing through. She is the whole thing. The ground everything else is built on. And from my side, that has never been in question for a single day.

The watch ticked. I held it in my hand. Felt its weight. Felt the strange way that weight felt like her.

Chapter 13: Everyone Else Feels Wrong

(And I never fully understood why until now)

When I am around other people — in conversations, in social situations, spending time with anyone who is not her — I feel off. Not sad. Not angry. Not obviously anything. Just wrong. Like I am in a room I do not belong in. Like my body knows the difference between where it is and where it should be, and it is quietly, constantly registering the gap.

Nothing lands the way it should. Nothing connects the way conversation is supposed to connect. I am present in the physical sense — I am there, I am responding, I am doing all the surface things correctly — but underneath all of that there is this steady, low-level awareness that something important is absent. Like background noise you did not notice until it stopped, except in reverse. Like I became aware of what the room sounded like with her in it, and now every room without her has this specific quality of insufficiency that I cannot un-hear.

I feel like I am wasting time. Every hour spent anywhere that is not near her feels like an hour that belongs somewhere else. Not dramatically. Not in a way I make a scene about. Just in the quiet, persistent way of knowing you are in the wrong place.

And then there is her. Where I can sit and just watch her for hours without a single second feeling like anything other than exactly what I should be doing. Like my eyes were made for exactly this purpose and I had just not found the right subject until now.

I love watching her. I love hearing her talk. I love when she tells me small things about her day — small enough that she is not even sure they are worth sharing, small enough that she almost doesn't say them, small enough that they feel like being trusted with something private — and I could listen to that for the rest of my life without it ever feeling like anything less than the best use of my time. Not because I am being patient or polite. Because it is genuinely, truthfully the best version of any hour I have ever had.

Everyone else disappears when she is near. Not because they leave. Because she arrives. And when she arrives, everything else becomes a slightly less real version of itself. She is just more real than other things. That is the only way I know how to put it.

I looked at the ceiling. Thought about the last time I had felt actually present somewhere. It was with her. It is always with her.

Chapter 14: The Matrix Moment

(The day I understood what I would never do again)

There is one memory that stays with me more than any other. More than the big ones, more than the obvious ones. One specific moment that changed something quietly and permanently, so quietly that I did not even notice it changing until I tried to go back to how I was before and found I couldn't.

We were talking. I was explaining this idea I had been thinking about — that the world is not real, that everything is a simulation, that nothing we experience has genuine substance. I was going deep into it the way I sometimes do when an idea gets hold of me. I was engaged. I was enjoying the conversation. I was not thinking about how it might land.

And she got emotional.

She stopped me. Her voice changed. She said: if all of this is fake, then what we have is not real either.

And she cried.

I stopped mid-sentence. Not on the outside. The words kept coming for one more second while something inside me went completely still. Then they stopped too.

I saw her eyes. I saw that tear. And something happened in me in that exact second that I cannot fully explain and have never been able to explain since. Some decision that was not decided so much as just made, the way the body makes decisions before the mind catches up. Never again. Not that idea. Not anything that could arrive at that place. That topic is gone from my life

forever.

Never again. That is the decision. Forever. Non-negotiable.

Not because the idea was wrong. Not because I was ashamed of thinking it. Because I saw one tear on her face, one single tear, and I decided in that moment with absolute clarity that I will never be the reason for that again. Whatever I have to give up, whatever ideas I have to leave alone, whatever conversations I have to redirect — I will always choose her not crying over me being right about something.

I don't know why her tears hit differently than anyone else's ever has. I can't explain the mechanism. I just know that they do. And I know that as long as I am anywhere near her world, I will do everything in my power to make sure she never has to cry. Every single time. Without exception.

One tear from her and I rearranged a piece of myself permanently. I have never gone back. I never will. That is not something you do for just anyone. That is not something you are even capable of doing for just anyone.

I thought about that tear for a long time. Just lying there in the dark with the weight of it. That single tear and what it cost her to let it show and what it did to me when it did.

Chapter 15: Not To Impress. Just To Make Her Smile.

(That's the whole reason. Always.)

There is a difference between doing something to impress someone and doing something to make them smile. The difference sounds small when you describe it but it is actually everything.

Impressing someone is about you. It is about how you appear, what they think of you, the image you create in their perception. It is fundamentally self-interested, even when it is dressed up as generosity. It is a performance with an audience and the audience is the point.

Making someone smile is completely about them. About their face in this moment. About adding one good thing to their day that would not have been there otherwise. It does not need to be witnessed. It does not need to be acknowledged. It does not need to produce any particular impression. It just needs to make them smile. That is the whole measurement.

Everything I have ever done for her — the obvious things, the quiet things, the things she does not know about and may never know about — none of it has ever been about how I look. It has never been a performance. It is always, only, just because I want to be the reason her day has one more good moment in it than it would have had without me. That is the entire calculation.

I built a website once. To express what I felt for her. Not to show her. Not to send her. Not to post. Just to build it. Because the feeling was real enough that it needed a form, needed somewhere to exist outside of just inside me, and she deserved to have something built for her even if she never saw it,

even if it only ever existed on a screen that only I looked at. That is what making someone smile looks like when it is real. You do it even when no one is watching. You do it even when there is nothing to gain. You do it because you just genuinely love doing it and she is the reason.

The irritating her. The phone screen turning off when she is using it. The wrong answers I give on purpose. The random sounds playing from nowhere. None of that is me trying to look like a certain kind of person. It is all just — I love her reaction. Every expression her face makes in response to something I did is the best version of that expression I have ever seen. The annoyance. The confusion. The reluctant recognition that it was me. The scolding that comes after. I would do all of it forever just to keep seeing those reactions.

I don't do things for her because I am trying. I do them because I genuinely love doing them. Because she smiles. And her smile is the whole reason. Every single time. That is it. That is the entire thing.

I laughed a little, alone in the dark. Just thinking about the sounds on her phone. The way she must have looked.

Chapter 16: I Love Being Wrong In Front Of Her

(And I would stay wrong forever just for this)

This one is embarrassing to admit. But I am admitting it anyway because this book promised to be honest and this is one of the honest things.

I love being wrong in front of her. Not the big important wrong — not the kind that matters, not the kind that affects anyone. The small everyday wrong. The wrong answers about small facts. The incorrect opinions about minor things. Because when I am wrong, she corrects me. And something about the specific experience of her correcting me is one of the best feelings I have ever had.

I do not fully understand it. I have tried to analyse it and I keep arriving at the same insufficient answer: it just does something to me. The moment she corrects me — the particular tone she uses, the little certain quality in her voice when she knows she's right, the way she says it like it is obvious and she is mildly exasperated that I did not know it too — something in me smiles from somewhere very deep. Not the surface smile. The one you feel in your chest before it reaches your face.

I will be honest about the full extent of this: I have pretended to be wrong. Deliberately. I have said things I knew were incorrect just to hear her correct me. I am not proud of this. I am also completely unable to stop because the payoff is worth it every single time. She comes in with the correction like she always does, confident and certain and slightly long-suffering, and I am sitting there already knowing the right answer and not caring even slightly because what I actually wanted was right here, this moment, right now.

For her corrections alone, I would happily be wrong for the rest of my life. Every single time. Without any hesitation.

There is something in it beyond just the enjoyment, though. Something it took me a while to name. When she corrects me, she is paying attention. She cares enough about what I said to engage with it, to set it straight, to make sure the record is accurate. That kind of presence — that specific quality of being heard and responded to and engaged with — is rare. And it is directed at me. Even when I earned it by being deliberately wrong about something I already knew.

I smiled again in the dark. Just me and the memory and nobody watching.

Chapter 17: I Love Irritating Her

(Don't ask me why. I genuinely do not know.)

Okay. This chapter exists. I am writing it with zero shame because every word of it is completely true and I refuse to pretend otherwise.

I love irritating her. I have no logical explanation for this. I have sat with the question and I keep arriving at the same answer: I just love it. There is no deeper reason. There is no theory about what it means. I just love doing it. It is genuinely one of my favourite things.

The phone screen turning off right when she is in the middle of using it. The random sounds suddenly playing from nowhere. The tiny, pointless, completely harmless things that have no purpose except to make her look up from whatever she is doing, look around in slight confusion, and then figure out it was me. That specific moment — the moment of realisation, when her face goes from confusion to recognition to mock exasperation — that is the moment. That is the one I am after every time.

But here is the actual best part. Here is the thing that makes all of it worth it ten times over.

When she scolds me.

When she gets actually annoyed and says something about it — that is better than almost anything. I genuinely cannot explain what it does to me. It is warm and funny and so completely, specifically her that I love every second of it. The particular way she says it. The specific indignation. The completely accurate observation that I did an unnecessary thing for no reason. All of it. But the voice notes when she is scolding — those are

something else entirely. That is the kind of thing I could listen to on repeat indefinitely and it would never stop being the single best thing in my phone. Her voice when she is scolding me about something silly is the warmest, most specific, most irreplaceable thing I have.

I irritate her because her reaction is the best thing. Her scolding is the best thing. Her voice notes are the best thing. Everything she does in response to me is the best thing. There is genuinely no losing in this situation.

Still smiling. And then I realised there was a tear in my eye at the same time. Happy and sad at exactly the same moment. That is what 3am does.

Chapter 18: She Makes Me Feel Like I Can Do Anything

(I don't know what magic this is but it is real)

I am not someone who needs someone to function. I want to be clear about that. I have always been self-sufficient in the truest sense. I have moved through hard things on my own, figured things out without help, kept going when keeping going required nothing but me. I do not need a person to make me capable.

And then there is her. And when she is near me, something happens that I cannot explain through any framework I have.

When she is next to me — not doing anything specific, not saying anything motivational, not performing support, just there, just herself in the same physical space — I feel like I can do anything. Genuinely. Every task that felt heavy becomes lighter. Every challenge that seemed slightly too large for me becomes manageable. Every slightly scary thing in front of me becomes something I am already moving toward instead of circling at a distance. Her presence does this. Without effort. Without intention. Just by being there.

I cannot explain the mechanism. I have tried. The version of me that has her nearby is measurably more capable, more confident, more present, more able to be fully himself than the version operating alone. She does not have to speak. She does not have to encourage. She just has to be in the same room.

It is like she is some kind of quiet power source. Not in a way that creates dependency — not in a way that makes me less without her, though I am. In a way that makes me more myself. Like her presence reminds me that the

world is okay. That I am okay. That whatever I am trying to do, I am the kind of person who can do it. She does not tell me that. She does not have to. Being near her just makes it feel true in a way it does not feel true otherwise.

*I don't know what magic this is. I just know that I am braver,
calmer, more capable, and more fully myself when she is beside me.
That is not nothing. That is one of the most important things in my
life.*

*I thought about the last time she was near me. How different everything felt. How easy it
all was.*

Chapter 19: I Always Hope It's Her

(Every morning. Every notification. Always.)

I will never tell her this directly. But I want it in writing because it is one of the truest things about me and it deserves to exist somewhere outside of just my own head.

Every single morning — before I am properly awake, before I have fully crossed the line from sleep to consciousness, before I have decided what kind of day it is going to be — I hope it is her. The first notification. The first buzz from my phone. The first sign that the day has started and the world is awake and something is happening. I hope, every single morning without exception, that it is her.

It almost never is. That is just the honest fact of it. She almost never reaches first. And that is okay. I am not angry about it. I have made a kind of peace with the hoping and the almost never. But the hoping does not stop. Every morning it is there again, undiminished, the same size it was on the very first morning I felt it. The same tiny quiet wish: let this be her. Let this day start with something from her.

Her call is the best start to any day I have ever had. Not because of what we talk about. Not because the conversations are always significant or meaningful. Just — her voice, first thing, before the day has finished forming. Before I have had to be anyone in particular. Before the performance has started. Her voice in that exact window is the best possible way any morning has ever begun for me. Nothing else comes close.

And even just a message. Even a single line she sent without thinking much about it, something small and ordinary that she maybe almost didn't send — that makes the whole day different. It lands somewhere warm inside me and stays there. Not loud. Not demanding attention all day. Just there, warm, like a light left on in a room.

Every morning I hope it's her. Every night I remember if it was. The days she reaches first are the best days. That is the simplest, most honest thing I know about myself.

I checked my phone. Still nothing. Put it face down. The hoping never stops. It just waits for morning.

Chapter 20: Just One Word

(I don't need much. Just this.)

I do everything without being asked. Without needing a reason. Without waiting to be told or prompted or convinced. I show up, I do the things, I am there — quietly, consistently, without making it into something that requires acknowledgement. That is just how I am with her. It does not feel like effort. It does not feel like sacrifice. It just feels like what I am doing.

And I do not need much in return. I genuinely mean that. This is not me performing generosity. I am not doing things for her and secretly keeping a tally and waiting to feel owed. I just do not need much. The doing is its own thing. Being able to do things for her is already its own reward.

But there is one thing. Just one small thing. The only thing I have ever quietly wanted from her.

Just tell me to take care of you. Or just say — I love you. Once. Just those words, said directly, said like they are real and not performed. Just so I know that you know. Just so it exists somewhere between us out loud and not only inside my head where I cannot be sure it is true.

I think about what I would feel if she said it. Even once. Even quietly, even casually, even like it was nothing. I feel like I could carry anything after that. I feel like I could carry everything. I do not know exactly why those specific words carry that specific weight for me — I cannot fully explain the mechanism. I just know that they do. I just know that if I heard them once, I would carry them for the rest of my life. And I would feel, carrying them, like I could carry the rest of my life too.

I don't need grand things. I just want to hear it once. That is the only thing I have ever asked for. One word. From her. Just once.

She does not have to say it today. She does not have to say it at all. I will still be here. Doing everything. Showing up. That is just how this is and it is not going to change. But I wanted to write it down somewhere — the one thing. The only thing. Just so it exists, in writing, in truth.

The room was very quiet. Just the ticking. Just me. Just that one thing I have never managed to ask for out loud.

Chapter 21: I Just Want More Time With Her

(Every moment. Every Saturday. Every ordinary day.)

We have memories. Good ones. Moments I hold in specific detail and would not trade for anything in the world. But here is the thing about memories: they are never enough. Every single one of them, instead of satisfying the longing, just makes it larger. Like each good memory is evidence of what is possible and that evidence makes the wanting worse, not better.

I want more Saturdays. More of the days when she has nowhere to be and no schedule pressing on her and she is just herself — unhurried, warm, fully present. The version of her that exists when nothing is demanding her. Those are the best days. Those are the ones I replay most.

I want to see her every day. I know that is not always possible and I am not asking for the impossible. But even if it is five minutes. Even if it is just being in the same space for a moment, just crossing into the same room. I would travel whatever it takes for five minutes. Without hesitation. Without calculating whether it is worth it. Because it always is.

Because time with her does not pass the way time usually passes. It does not press on you. It does not run out. It just feels like being somewhere you are supposed to be. Like the hours know they are the right hours. Softer than other hours. Fuller. More worth something when they end because you were in them properly.

I want every free day. Every ordinary Tuesday when nothing is happening and we could just be near each other. Every five minutes that could be spent in the same space as her. All of it. Every single

piece of it. I want it all.

I want to be the reason she has good memories. Not the dramatic kind. The quiet ordinary kind — the kind that come back to you unexpectedly on a random afternoon and make you feel warm for no reason you can immediately identify. I want to be somewhere in that warmth. I want to be the person who showed up, who was there, who made sure she felt like she was worth the effort — because she is worth more effort than I could ever give her and I want to spend my whole life trying anyway.

I thought about an ordinary afternoon with her. Nothing special about it. Just her being near. Just that. How that is actually the most special thing I know.

Chapter 22: She Is My Moon

(And this is why I will never go anywhere)

Moons do not announce themselves. They do not arrive with noise or fanfare. They do not demand that you look up at them. They just appear. And when you do look up — when you happen to raise your eyes at the right moment — they are there, hanging in the dark, and the whole world looks different in their light than it did a moment before. Not dramatically different. Just — more itself. More visible. More real.

That is her.

She did not try to change me. She did not arrive with a plan to fix me or improve me or make me into something better than what I was. She just showed up — in calls, in snaps I checked every 15 minutes like my life depended on them, in ‘you okay?’ messages that always landed at exactly the moment I needed them and somehow she always knew when that was. She just was herself. And her being herself, completely and without performance, was enough to change everything about who I was. Not by design. Just by existing in my world.

I called her Moon because of the light. Because of the way everything has more texture when she is around. More warmth. More reality. Like without her my world is technically functional but slightly flat, slightly dim, missing some quality of light that I did not know was missing until I felt what it was like to have it. And now I know. And now I cannot unknow it.

People look at the moon every night of their lives and it never stops being something. It is the same moon, in the same sky, doing the same thing it has

always done, and yet you look up at it and you feel something every single time. You feel it even when you cannot name what you are feeling. That is exactly what she does to me. Every call, every message, every snap, every random moment when she surfaces in my day. Every single time. Without diminishing. Without becoming ordinary.

And I tried to leave. I want to be honest about that. I did not stay quietly and accept the situation. I tried, actively, with everything I had, to create distance and to make it work. I lasted a month. I gave the distance everything.

And the distance gave me back one thing: there is no version of my life that works better without her than with her. Not one. I checked every angle. I checked every day for thirty days. The answer was the same every time.

Life without her — then what is the point of any of it? I asked myself that every day for a month. And every day the answer was the same. No point at all. None.

So on March 25, 2026, I called her. She picked up. I couldn't speak. And everything was okay.

She is my moon.

She will be valued like no one else.

She will be respected like no one else.

She will be prioritised like nothing else.

She will be cared for like no one else.

She will never have to ask. Because the answer is always yes.

I looked up at the ceiling in the dark. The word came back again. Moon. Her.

Chapter 23: My Wishlist

(Simple things. The only things that actually matter.)

These are the things I want. Not the grand things. Not the dramatic declarations. Just the simple, specific, ordinary things that would make my life exactly right. With her.

I want her to choose me. On her own. Without being asked. Without being convinced or persuaded or presented with an argument. Just her, in a quiet moment, looking at everything clearly, and choosing me. That is the first wish and the biggest wish and everything else starts there because without that, none of the rest of it means what it should mean.

I want the hesitation to go. I want her to be able to sit with me without the careful measuring, without the monitoring of how much she is giving, without the held-back quality that I feel in her sometimes and which I understand but which breaks my heart a little every time. I want her to be easy with me the way she is easy with herself. Because with me, she is always safe. That has never changed.

I want to hug her. A real one. The kind where you actually hold on and the other person holds back and the world stops demanding things from you for a moment. Not a polite hug, not a social gesture. A real one. As many times as possible. Every time I can.

I want to visit places with her. It does not need to be far. It does not need to be planned. Just her and me somewhere, moving through the world together, making something to remember. Something that belongs to us.

I want to grow with her. Both of us becoming more, both of us building something, both of us moving in the same direction at the same time and being able to look sideways and see the other one there.

I want full days with her. No rush, no clock, nowhere to be. Just days that belong to nobody else and nothing else. Days where time moves differently because we are in it together.

I want to eat with her. Something ordinary. Just sitting across from her, sharing food, having a normal human meal. The most normal thing in the world. With her. That is the whole wish.

I want to be there on her bad days. Not to fix anything. Just to be there. So she knows that on the hard days, she does not have to be alone in it. I want to be the person she thinks of when things are hard.

I want to hear her laugh so hard she cannot stop. That specific laugh. The real one. And I want to be the reason for it.

I want to call her every morning freely. Like it is the most natural thing in the world. Like there is no weight on it, no question of whether it is allowed, no careful calculating of whether now is an okay time. Just: calling her. Like it is what I do. Like it is just true.

I want to be her safe place. The first person she thinks of when she needs someone. I want to be the name that comes up in her mind before she has even finished forming the thought of needing help.

I want to tell her everything in this book. Out loud. With words. One day.
Looking at her face when I say it.

**And the last one. The one I think about most. The one I would give
everything else up for. I want to see her face when she finally reads this.**

*Simple things. Real things. Ordinary things. The only things that
actually matter when you ask yourself what you actually want from
this life.*

*There was a tear in my eye. And a smile on my face. Both at exactly the same time. I
didn't wipe either one. I just let them both be there.*

Chapter 24: Why I Left

(It was never about me)

People assume when someone leaves, they stopped caring. That the leaving is evidence of absence of feeling. I need to say this once, clearly, so it is in writing somewhere: I left because I cared. That is the complete truth. That is the only reason. There is no other version.

She was confused. I could feel it. Not in a dramatic, visible way — she never made it into something dramatic. It was quiet. It lived in small gaps. The pause before she answered that was slightly too long. The way she sometimes went somewhere else in the middle of a conversation, present in body but thinking about something I was not allowed to see. She was choosing. Between him and me. And she had not chosen yet.

I am not angry about that. I have never been angry about that. You cannot argue someone into certainty. You cannot push someone to choose you before they are ready and have it mean what it needs to mean. I was not going to do that. Not because I didn't want to. Because I understood that a choice made under pressure is not a choice at all.

Then she broke her leg.

I kept it together in front of everyone. From the outside I was calm. Measured. Fine.

But alone — I cried.

Her pain arrived in my chest like it belonged there. Not metaphorically. Physically. Like my body received the news and decided it was personal. It hurt the way things hurt when they happen to you, not when they happen to someone else. And that told me something I had been trying not to fully acknowledge.

I went to see her. She had waited for me. That detail — that she waited — still sits with me in a particular way.

But when I offered to drop her somewhere, she refused. Called her mom. Said the bike was difficult with her leg. That was true. But when I looked at her face I saw something that had nothing to do with the bike. Something in the line of her jaw, the quality of her eyes, the slight withdrawal in her posture. She was trying to maintain distance. Not to hurt me. She just didn't have the words for it, so her body said it instead. I saw it. I didn't say anything. I just felt it land in my chest and went home and sat with it.

I had been noticing other things too.

She used to call first. That was just the rhythm we had. Then slowly, without announcement, without explanation, it changed. The calls became mine to make. Sometimes she picked up. Sometimes she didn't. Messages stopped coming from her side first. The small daily reach that used to just happen stopped happening.

I know it came from confusion. I know it was not cruelty. But I noticed every change the way you notice things when someone is the most important thing in your world. Every small shift. Every thing that used to be there and quietly wasn't anymore.

And I made a decision. Not for myself. Her exams were coming. Her leg was broken. She was already carrying everything. I did not want to be one more thing. I did not want to be pressure in her life. Not from my side. Not ever from my side.

I got a call. A good one. And my first thought — not my second thought, my first — was her. Her future. Her career. The life she was building. And I felt this specific happiness that had nothing in it for me. Pure happiness on behalf of someone else. The kind you can only feel for someone who has become more important to you than yourself.

I called her immediately. I could not even organise my words properly. Asked when her exams finished. April 16th. Then asked how they were going.

‘Not nice,’ she said.

I sat with that answer for a long time. I had thought space would help her focus. I had genuinely believed that. But her answer told me I had misread her completely. She does not work well in empty space. She works well with someone pushing. Someone who believes in her enough to refuse to let her coast. That was always me. And I had removed myself thinking I was lightening her load. I had actually just taken away the thing that made her feel like her exams mattered to someone.

I changed immediately. Started checking in. Sending her things. Being there.

Then one night she replied to something I sent.

‘I have learned to live without you.’

I read it once. Then again. Then I put my phone down and didn't pick it up for a while.

Not from anger. Not from pride. I just did not know what to say. Those words came from somewhere real in her. From a month of work she had done on herself in my absence. She had built something without me and she wanted me to know it was real.

I respect that. I genuinely do.

But here, in this book, in this 3am honesty where there is nobody to perform for:

I never learned to live without you. I tried. I tried for a month with everything I had. I failed every single day. Not once did it get easier. Not once did the missing get smaller. She is stronger than me in this. She has always been stronger than me in most things. This is just one more.

If she is happy — genuinely, quietly, fully happy in whatever life she is building — then every second of that month was worth it. The sleeplessness. The not eating. The performance I wore every day. The nights I stayed up thinking about her future more than my own. All of it. Worth it completely.

But if there is any part of her that still wonders. If some morning she picks up her phone and starts a thought she doesn't finish. If there is any small unresolved thing living quietly in her chest the way this question lives in mine —

I am not gone. I am not angry. I am not anywhere difficult to reach.

I am exactly where I have always been.

I left for her. I cried for her in private while performing okay for everyone else. And I would do all of it again, every painful second, without changing a single thing. That is just the honest truth of what this is.

I breathed slowly. The room. The dark. The watch still counting. Still there.

Chapter 25: What Other People Taught Me

(The emptiness that made everything clear)

I don't know why people trust me. I have never fully understood it. But somewhere in all the trusting, all the people coming close, all the conversations that have happened between me and other people over the years — I noticed something that changed how I understand everything. Including her.

There are girls who want me. I am not saying this to sound like something. I am saying it because it matters to what comes after.

They talk to me. They are kind to me. They find ways to be near me and ways to ask without asking whether I feel what they feel. I understand all of it. The indirect questions. The longer-than-necessary conversations. The particular quality of attention that means something more than it says. I understand every signal.

I just feel nothing.

Zero. Complete, total, unambiguous zero. No flicker. No possibility. Not even curiosity. Just nothing. And because I feel nothing — because I understand that you cannot give someone warmth you do not actually have, that presence without feeling is a kind of cruelty — I step back. I give cold replies. I create distance. Not from cruelty but from honesty. Because the alternative is worse.

But one of them I need to be specifically honest about.

She is not just someone flirting. She genuinely believes in me. The way she talks about me, the way she shows up, the way she trusts me without any evidence that I deserve it — all of it is real. I can feel that it is real. She is falling. I can see it happening as clearly as I can see anything and I cannot stop it and I cannot meet it because I feel nothing. Even for her. Even for someone this genuine and this kind.

I am sorry. That is the only honest thing I have for her. I am genuinely sorry.

I am creating distance from her. Slowly, carefully, not cruelly. Not because she did anything wrong. Because she deserves someone who actually feels what she feels. Someone for whom she is the answer and not the reminder that the answer is somewhere else. I am just not that person. I cannot be. I am not that person for anyone in the world except one.

And that is the moment when it hit me. Sitting with all of this — the girls I feel nothing for, the kindness I cannot receive, the warmth I cannot return — I thought about her.

And I thought: what if this is exactly how she feels about me?

What if when I call, she picks up because not picking up would feel unkind, and not because she needs to hear my voice? What if from her side, the feeling I carry — this enormous, consuming, nowhere-else-it-goes feeling — what if it simply isn't there? What if I am to her what these girls are to me — someone she is kind to, someone she does not want to hurt, someone she does not quite know how to put distance between herself and?

If that is true. If I am that to her. Then I am not her person. I am just someone who loves her from a direction she has not turned toward.

I refuse to be an emotional burden on the person I love most. That is the line. That is the thing I will not cross.

That thought sat in me for a long time. It still does. It is one of the hardest things I have had to face honestly. Not that she doesn't care. She does care. I know she does. But caring is not the same as feeling. Caring does not always go in the same direction as love. I know this now better than I ever wanted to.

I might be wrong about all of this. I hope I am. I genuinely hope I have read it all completely backwards and what I think is her kindness is actually something else entirely and one day she will show me how wrong I was.

But I cannot build my life on hoping. So I have one wish. Just one.

I am asking God. Because I can take care of what is in front of me. I have my family, my work, my life, the people within my reach. But she is not within my reach. She is somewhere I cannot get to right now. So I am asking the only thing that can reach everywhere.

Just take care of her. Make sure she eats. Make sure her exams go well. Make sure whoever is around her treats her the way she deserves. Make sure she is warm and okay. I will handle everything in front of me. Just keep her okay.

She lost someone who loved her like mad. And I lost her. I want to say that clearly because it goes both ways — this was not something that happened to only one of us. We both lost something real and neither of us got to say so properly.

That person is still here. Not waiting in some paralysed way. Not stuck. Living, building, moving, showing up. But still here. Not angry. Not resentful. Just — here.

If she ever wants to find me, I am not hiding.

If she doesn't — take care. I mean that with every good thing I have.

I couldn't feel anything for anyone else. And that taught me something I didn't want to learn — that she might feel the same way about me. I accepted it. It hurt the way very true things hurt. I accepted it anyway. That is the most loving thing I have ever done.

I stared at the ceiling for a long time after that thought. Just breathing. Just being with it.

Chapter 26: 3am and the Watch

(April 6. One long, honest night.)

I came back to the room.

The dark. The music still playing softly from my phone. The watch still in my hand.

Tik. Tik. Tik.

I lay there holding it. Just listening to it count the seconds. The same sound that had pulled me out of sleep. Still going. Still steady. Every second accounted for. Every second it had been counting since she put it in my hands.

And then the thought came.

The one that only arrives at 3am. The one that the daylight keeps at a manageable distance but the dark, the silence, the honest hour — they let it through.

Was I ever her preference?

I held that question carefully because it is a sharp one. If I was — if I was genuinely what she wanted, the person she would choose if she could choose freely — she would not have left. That is just the simple logic of it. When someone is your preference you find a way. You choose them. You stay, even when staying is harder. She didn't stay.

Which means either I was never her preference. Or something was so tangled and confusing inside her that she left even the person she preferred. I

have been turning those two options over for months and I do not know which one is true. I do not know which one hurts more to sit with.

And then I thought about something she said. That she was not planning to marry him.

I have turned that sentence over more times than I can count. If it is true — if she left me for someone she was not even planning to build a life with — then did she do right by me? That question has no answer. Not one she can give me and not one I can give myself. It will just live in me. Unanswered. The way certain true things live in you, not resolved, just present.

Like the ticking.

I got up. Drank water. Stood in the dark for a minute with the glass in my hand, just standing there, not thinking about anything specific, just being in my body for a moment. Came back. Lay down. Picked up the watch again.

I stopped asking her things a while ago. Stopped pushing. Stopped sending the messages that were really questions. Stopped waiting for answers that were not going to come. Not because I stopped caring. Because she closed a door. And I could feel the weight of it when it closed and I understood. There is no point in standing outside a closed door calling a name. The door is closed. That is the information.

And now I have nothing in my hand. No move left. No message I can send. No reach that is allowed. Just this room and this dark and this watch and all the thoughts that have no place to go except here, inside, in the only space that is still mine.

I came back to the room and I lay down.

No ego. Nothing like that. No anger. No hurt feeling sitting in my chest wanting to make itself known. Just — me. And her. And the dark. And the watch still going.

I opened her photos. Every saved one. Going through them one by one. Not scrolling. Going. Each photo I stayed inside for a second before moving to the next. Her face. The moments. All of it.

Then I was reading a poem on my phone notes. Just sitting there in the dark reading it slowly. Then I looked up at my wallpaper. Her photo. Her face. I just stared at it.

And then I felt it.

There was a tear. In the corner of my left eye. One drop, right there at the edge, ready to fall. I felt it forming. I felt the exact weight of it.

I didn't let it fall.

But both my eyes were wet. Fully wet. Just sitting there, eyes wet, one drop held at the corner, not letting it go.

And at the same time — at exactly the same time — there was a smile on my face. A gentle one. Not a big smile. Not the kind you show people. A quiet, decent smile. The kind that arrives without being asked. The kind that just shows up on your face because something true is happening inside you and your face responds to it before you can decide whether to show it.

Both things together. The wet eyes. The held tear. The quiet smile.

And in my chest — something I cannot name. Something I don't have a word for. It was like there was someone inside, someone small, who was playing and laughing and crying and being completely alive with every emotion at once. All of it. Happy, sad, in love, missing her, peaceful, aching — all of it in the same space, all of it true at the same moment, none of it cancelling the other out.

The most peaceful moment. The most satisfying thing I have ever felt.

I know that sounds strange. Wet eyes and a held tear and all of that, and I am saying peaceful. But it is true. There was real peace in me. Underneath everything. A peace that had nothing to do with the situation being okay and everything to do with the feeling being completely, honestly real.

No performance anywhere. Nobody watching. Nothing to prove. Just me at 3am holding a tear I would not let fall and smiling without anyone asking me to.

That feeling. I cannot explain it. I just know it was the most real thing I have ever felt in my life.

Her music was playing. She had sent it hours earlier. I had forgotten it was on. The same song on loop. I had been playing it again and again without noticing. And now I noticed.

I kept playing it. Again. And again. And again.

I kept saying her name. Not out loud. Inside. Again and again, the way you repeat something that feels too good and too painful to stop. Her name. Her

name. Her name.

This is the most real moment I have ever lived.

Not the most happy. Not the most peaceful, though there was a kind of peace in it too. The most real. Because it was completely, uncomplicatedly true. Everything I felt was real. The love. The loss. The unanswered question. The tear. The smile. All of it true at the same time, no performance anywhere, nothing managed or curated or presented. Just me at 3am being completely honest with myself for once.

She is the best.

She was always the best.

She will always be the best.

And underneath everything — underneath the tear and the smile and the music and the question — I felt it again.

She is not okay right now. I can feel it. Some quiet certainty in my body, the way I always feel things about her before she tells me, the way I notice her before she shows me. She is carrying something. I do not know what it is. I asked her earlier and she did not say. She kept it to herself the way she always does when something is too heavy — carefully, quietly, not wanting to be a weight on anyone.

I cannot fix it tonight. I cannot reach through the screen and take it from her. I cannot be there. I am not allowed to be there right now.

But I want her to know — even here, even in this honest 3am with the question still sitting unanswered in my chest — part of me is sitting with her.

Wherever she is. Whatever she is carrying. She is not alone in it. She has never been alone in it, even when I have been the last person she would think to call.

She deserves the lightest, softest days. She always has. I hope tomorrow is one of them.

Tik. Tik. Tik.

3am. A glowing watch. A tear and a smile that arrived together. Her music. Her name on repeat. And a question that will never have an answer. And peace anyway. Somehow, underneath everything, peace anyway.

I put the watch back in the drawer. I could still hear it through the wood. Tik. Tik. Tik.

Chapter 27: I Saw Her Today

(Maybe the last chapter. Maybe not.)

I saw her today.

I don't know if she saw me. She looked in my direction at some point. Maybe she did. Maybe she didn't register me. I don't know. I just know that I saw her, completely and immediately and with the specific quality of recognition that only happens with people who have been deeply important to you.

I was drinking tea.

And suddenly there she was.

The urge to call her name was immediate. Physical. Like something in my throat jumped before my brain had time to weigh in. Her name was right there, ready, already formed.

I didn't say it.

Because she told me she was in peace without me. She said that. Those words. And something in me went afraid at the idea of my voice being the thing that disturbed that peace. Of all the things I could be to her, I did not want to be the one who broke the quiet she had finally found. So I stayed quiet. And I watched.

She was in the kind of rush she has when somewhere is waiting for her. Phone in her hand. She ordered tea. Got a call. Talked for a bit. Then she walked to the counter. Paid. And left.

A few minutes. Maybe less. That was the whole thing.

But I noticed everything. That is just what I do with her. I noticed the tiredness behind her eyes — not the one-bad-night kind but the kind that builds over time. I noticed how she held her phone. The way she moved — purposeful but not easy. She was carrying something. I could feel it the way I always feel things about her that she does not say out loud.

I was right behind her. The whole time. Completely unable to be anything other than completely aware of her.

She paid.

And then she left.

And then I walked to the same counter. And I paid.

One counter. She paid first and walked out. I paid after. Same counter. Same shop. Same cup of tea.

We used to always pay together. That is just how it was. One of us would pay, that is all, one thing, one moment. We never thought about it.

And now she paid and walked out before I even got to the counter. And I stood there after she left, alone at that same counter, and I paid my own cup of tea. And I felt something. Not dramatic. Not loud. Just that specific, quiet, heavy feeling of something that used to be whole now being two separate things.

The most unsatisfied I have felt in a long time. Not heartbroken. Not angry. Just — that exact feeling of a sentence that stopped one word before it should have ended.

Maybe she wants a complete cutoff. Maybe that is what today was — a quiet, practical demonstration of the new arrangement.

If that is what she needs, then that is fine. I mean that without performance. If her life is lighter and more peaceful and more okay without me in it, then every painful second of all of this was worth it. Her being okay is the only metric I have ever measured anything by.

Cute little panda. Cute moon.

Even from a distance. Even paying separate. Even with all the space between us that did not used to be there. Still the same. Still her. Still the person I will think of last thing at night and first thing in the morning for as long as I live.

I cannot move on from her. I want to be honest about that. That is not how this works for me and I have stopped pretending it might be.

But I can move in my life. And I am.

I started attending the meetings. Real ones — for the work, for the apps, for everything we are building. I am showing up for things I used to postpone. The tuition app is working. People are connecting with it. Response is good.

From next session I am giving regular classes. I got an offer. I said yes.

She will be proud of me. Even if she never tells me. Even if she never knows the full shape of what I have built. She will hear about it somewhere and she will feel something and I know what that something will be. I know her. I know how she feels about people who show up and do the work.

She was afraid I would drop everything. That was one of her fears about me. That I would leave my career, leave my responsibilities, walk away from everything that was supposed to matter in pursuit of something that might not work out. That was the fear she had. I understood it then. I still understand it.

I am making it false. One day at a time. One meeting, one class, one session, one hour of real work at a time. Not for her — for me. Because I deserve to be the person who does not drop everything. Because I have always been capable of being that person and I am going to be it.

Her regret into happiness. Her fear into something she can point to and feel proud of.

This might be the last chapter of this book. Maybe she has decided and the story ends here, quietly, with tea and separate payments and the kind of distance that does not need to announce itself.

But the book of my life is not ending. It keeps going. It is going well. It will keep going better.

And wherever she is — I hope one day she opens this. I hope she reads every page and understands that every single word was just me, loving her, in the only way I ever knew how. Completely. Without any cool about it. Without any distance or performance or careful management. Just completely.

I saw her today. She looked tired. I was right behind her and I said nothing. We paid separate and it was the most unsatisfying moment I have had in a long time. But then I came home and I started

*working again. Because she deserves someone who doesn't stop.
And I deserve to be that person.*

*I thought about the tea. The separate payments. The space between us that used to not be
there. I thought about it for a long time.*

Chapter 28: The Night I Couldn't Breathe

(Some feelings don't have words. This one didn't.)

I had a feeling I couldn't explain.

Not a thought. Not a worry. Something underneath both of those things. Something in the body before the mind gets involved. This quiet, heavy certainty that arrived without being invited: something is wrong. With her. Right now. Somewhere.

I do not know how to describe it more precisely than that because it was not precise. It was just there. Certain. Heavy. Like a fact that has not been spoken yet but is already true.

I messaged her.

She told me she wanted to cry.

That was all she said. Those words. She wanted to cry.

And something in me broke open.

Not dramatically. Not with noise. Just — broke. The way a wall breaks when the thing it was holding back finally has enough weight. All at once, everything I had been keeping at a manageable distance just came forward.

I asked what happened. I asked if she was okay. She said nothing for a moment. Then she said she would be fine.

She would be fine.

I sat with those three words. I tried to find comfort in them and I could not. Not because I doubted that she would be fine eventually — she would be,

she always is, she is stronger than anyone I know. But because the distance between those words and what I was feeling in my chest was the longest distance I have ever experienced. She was somewhere being not fine right now and I was here unable to do anything and the gap between those two facts was the size of everything.

My body did something I did not ask it to do.

It went heavy. All at once. Like the weight had moved from somewhere invisible into everywhere physical simultaneously. I could not breathe properly. Not in the way of a panic attack, not with drama — just the air felt thick. Wrong. Like I was trying to breathe through something dense. My mouth went dry. I noticed my hands were sweating. I had not noticed I was sweating until I looked at my hands.

I bought water. A bottle. Drank the whole thing standing up, a full litre, one continuous motion, like my body was trying to process something through sheer volume of fluid. It did not help the way I hoped it would. The heaviness was still there. The thick air was still there. She was still somewhere not okay and I was still here unable to reach her.

I could not go home. That was clear to me immediately and absolutely. If I went home I would be alone with it and alone with it was not survivable. Not that night. Not with that weight pressing on my chest from the inside.

So I called my friends.

I did not tell them what had happened. I said nothing about her. I did not explain the weight or the thick air or the litre of water. I just showed up. And

they looked at me — the way people who actually know you look at you when something is wrong — and they understood without being told. Something was wrong with me. They did not ask. They just stayed. That is the kind of friendship that matters. Not the kind that asks questions. The kind that just stays.

We drove. We did not go home. We drove through the night because driving felt like the only thing possible with a body that did not know where to put what it was carrying. Just movement. Just the road and the dark and the changing of songs when one ended.

One of them fell asleep. Then the other. And then it was just me. 2am. The road. The dark. The sound of them sleeping. Both of them down, both of them somewhere peaceful, and me still awake with all of it, changing the songs by myself, watching the night pass.

I pulled over near a shop that was still open. I took a chair from outside. Ordered tea. Lit a cigarette. And I started writing.

I kept writing until 4pm the next day. Without stopping. Not because I had a plan for what to write. Not because I knew where it was going. Because writing was the only way I could be with her when I was not allowed to be with her. The only way to hold something I could not touch. If I could not reach her then I could at least reach the words, and maybe the words could reach somewhere she was.

This book started that night.

One of my friends woke up eventually. We went to a temple together. All three of us, early morning, the light still deciding what kind of day it would be.

I never used to ask for things at temples. That is not how I am. I go. I stand. I feel whatever is there to feel. But I do not ask. It always felt like the wrong transaction — like going to a place of presence and treating it like a vending machine.

But that morning I asked.

I stood there and I spoke from somewhere deep in my chest. Not out loud. No sound. Just from inside, in the most honest register I have, without performance, without negotiation, without asking for anything for myself:

‘Whatever it is — solve her problem. I am not there to take care of her. I cannot be there right now. This is the only thing I can do for her from here. Just take care of her.’

That was it. That was the whole prayer. Not for us. Not for me. Not asking for her to come back or to choose me or for the situation to resolve in any particular way. Just: she has a problem and I cannot reach it and please let someone or something reach it for me.

Because that was all I had left. That was the full extent of what I could do for her. And I gave it everything.

She has probably thought I have moved on from her. I understand why she would think that. From the outside, from the distance she has put between us, from the absence of reaching from my side — it probably looks like

moving on.

She is wrong.

Moving on in my life is something I have done. The work is real. The apps are real. The classes are real. The showing up is real. I am moving in my life. That is true and I am not going to pretend it isn't.

But moving on from her is a different thing entirely and I have not done it. I cannot do it. I do not believe there is a version of me that will ever do it. She will be the same for me in ten years as she is right now. Whatever the world looks like, whatever either of us builds, whatever life does — she will be the same.

I ask myself sometimes: will she open the door?

The honest answer is I don't know. I hope she will. I hope she does it soon, because carrying the hope is heavy in a way that I am managing but that I feel. But I do not know.

What I know is that I will be here when she does. Not frozen, not stopped, not waiting in some suspended way that makes a cage of the waiting. Just — here. Living. Building. Moving through my life with everything I have. But here.

That night — the water, the car, the chair outside the shop at 2am, the writing that became this book, the temple at dawn — I was looking at the moon from outside.

It was beautiful. Just hanging there in the sky, doing what it does, being what it is. Beautiful and steady and completely itself regardless of whether anyone

was looking.

Just like her.

And for a moment everything was very simple. She was hurting somewhere and the moon was being beautiful somewhere and I was down here loving her from a distance, in the only way I still could, writing the words she had not read yet and would not read until the right time.

I couldn't breathe. My body didn't know where to put it. I drove through the night, wrote until afternoon, prayed without making a sound. All of it for her. All of it because she said three words and I had nothing left to give her except this.

I got up from the bed. Walked to the window. Looked for the moon. It was still there.

Chapter 29: April 12. One Minute After Waking Up.

(I have an important meeting today. I just wish she was here.)

It is morning now.

April 12. I just woke up. Maybe one minute ago. And I am writing this before I have done anything else. Before I have even stood up properly. Because this feeling is here right now and I do not want to lose it.

I have an important meeting today. A very important one. I know that. I am ready for it. I have been working quietly, preparing without telling anyone, doing everything that can be done in silence. I like that. Working in silence. Not because I am hiding. Because I love the work more when nobody is watching it happen. When results are the only announcement.

I do not know if that is the right way to do things. I just know it is my way. And it has always been my way.

But right now, in this first minute of this morning, before the meeting and before the day and before any of the things I need to be and do today — the first thing I felt when I opened my eyes was a wish.

I wish she was here. Right now. Just beside me.

Not for anything specific. Not to talk about the meeting or to get encouragement or to have a reason. Just — beside me. Her presence in the same space. That is the whole wish. That one small thing.

I am not quitting my career. I feel that clearly this morning and I want to write it clearly. My career is a priority. A real one. Everything I am building — the apps, the classes, the work I do in silence — all of it is real and all of it matters. None of it is going away.

But she is also a priority. I do not feel any conflict in that. I do not feel like choosing her is choosing wrong. She is a priority the same way breathing is. Not in competition with everything else. Just — there. Necessary. Real.

I do not always have the words for the specific way she sits in my chest as something important. But she does. She is there. Every morning. First thing.

And then — just now, while writing this — I noticed I had been gone for about fifteen minutes.

Not asleep. Not distracted. Just gone. Somewhere inside my own head, completely still. And what I was lost in was this: she left. She actually left. She left knowing I cannot handle it. She knows me. She knows I cannot. I know I cannot. We both know it. And she left anyway.

There is only one thing I ever gave completely from the inside of my heart. One thing. And she left with it.

I have had hard times before. Real ones. The kind that press on you from every direction. And I took every single one. Not just took them — took them with a smile. A quiet one. Not performed, not for anyone to see. But real. Even the hardest moments did not wet my eyes. Not once in all the years of all the hard things I have been through. My eyes stayed dry. I did not know they could be anything else.

But this one is different.

Nowadays my eyes are always a little wet. Always searching. And right now, writing this, one drop fell.

I can lie to the world. I am good at it. The performance, the shrug, the unbothered face. All of it I can produce.

But I cannot lie to my own heart. I wish I could. It would be easier. But I cannot.

Did she make me soft? Or was I always this way underneath everything, and she just found it? I cannot tell anymore where I end and where what she did to me begins. They have become the same thing.

My eyes are wet right now. Both of them. And I am holding the tears, not letting them fall, just holding them the way you hold something you are not ready to put down.

There is something in my chest I cannot name. Something without a word for it. Not sadness exactly. Not happiness exactly. Something that sits underneath both of those. More fundamental.

The best image I have for it: she made a pond. Full of water, full of life. She put me in it. I lived in it, completely, without knowing that is what I was doing. And then she took the water away. And now I am here, in the space where the water was, still shaped like something that was submerged, still carrying what it felt like to be that full.

I do not know if that makes sense. It is just what came.

There is pain. Yes. Real pain that I am not going to dress up as something it is not.

And my eyes are wet. That is just the truth of this morning.

But there is also a smile on my face. A real one. Not the kind I put there for other people. The kind that arrives on its own from somewhere true, the kind you do not perform, the kind that means something because it was not planned.

The pain is beautiful.

I know that sounds impossible. I know that before her I would not have believed that sentence. I would have said: pain is not beautiful, do not dress it up in words to make it sound chosen.

But I am having this feeling right now. One minute after waking up on April 12 with wet eyes and a smile I did not put there and an important meeting ahead of me. Purely true. Before I have had time to build defences. Before the day has started. Just the raw first moment of being awake.

The pain is beautiful. Everything she gave me, everything she made me feel, even this particular shape of missing her on a regular morning — it is beautiful. I do not know how. I cannot explain it. I just know it the way you know true things when there is nobody watching.

I do not know what I want to say. I mean that completely. I am writing one minute after waking up with nowhere specific to go. I just have this feeling and it needed to be in the book because this book holds all the real things.

And this is one of the real things.

The meeting is today. I am ready. I will go. I will do everything that needs to be done. That part of my life is moving and it will keep moving.

But first, in this first minute of this morning, I am here.

Eyes wet. Smiling. Holding the pain like it is something precious.

Missing her in the most quiet, most complete, most honest way I know how.

Whatever it takes — I hope she calls.

*I put the phone down. Got up. The morning was waiting. The day was waiting. Everything
I promised to build was waiting.*

Chapter 30: Happy New Year, Moon.

(The last thing I write. For now.)

I don't know why I am writing this.

Honestly. I have been asking myself that the whole time. Why put it all down. Why turn everything into pages. Why write 30 chapters to someone who has not read a single one.

The only answer I have: I just needed somewhere to put it all. And this was the only place that would hold everything without asking me to explain myself.

So I wrote.

It is a new year.

Happy New Year. Happy Biska Jatra.

Happy New Year, Moon.

I hope this year is gentle with you. I hope it gives you the mornings you deserve. I hope your work goes well. I hope the people around you are kind. I hope you rest properly. I hope you laugh more than last year. I hope everything that felt heavy slowly gets lighter.

That is the whole wish. That is all of it.

I am not going to ask for anything.

I know myself well enough to say this: if asking would bring her back to me, I would ask. If setting aside every other thing would bring her back, I would set it aside. Self respect, self value, all of it — none of it would stop me if I thought it would work.

But I know that is not how this goes. So I am not asking.

I am just saying, quietly, in the last page of this book:

If you ever want to come back — I am here. I have always been here. I will still be here.

No questions. No pressure. No explanation needed.

Just here.

I am doing well. I want her to know that properly. The work is real. The apps are moving. The classes are coming. The meetings are happening. Everything I said I would build, I am building. Quietly, in the way I love to work, without making noise about it until it is done.

I have moved forward in my life. That is true and real.

But I have not moved on from her. I never will. Those two things look the same from the outside but they are completely different. I have done the first. The second is not something I am capable of.

If she ever comes back —

I know exactly what I will do.

I will hug her. A real one. The kind where you hold on properly and the whole world goes quiet for a moment. And the tears will come — mine, with peace in them, not sadness, just relief. That specific feeling of something returning that you had given up hoping would return.

A smile on my face. Wet eyes. The most peaceful I have ever been.

That is the image I carry.

I am going to close the laptop now.

This book has said everything it needed to say. The 3am things. The morning things. The tea shop things. The watch things. The month of no sleep things. All of it is here, in writing, waiting for the day it reaches her.

So I am waiting.

Like I have always been waiting.

Waiting for her call.

Waiting for her message.

Always in love with her.

Happy New Year, Moon. ■

I don't know why I wrote all of this. I just know I could not not write it. And I know one day she will read every word. And I know what I hope her face will do when she does.

I closed the laptop. The watch was still ticking in the drawer. Tik. Tik. Tik. Always.

Chapter 31: Something I Did Quietly.

(She didn't know. That was always the point.)

Before the new year, I got a call.

A friend of mine — a senior UI/UX designer — told me there was a position open at his company. Mid-level. Work from home. Salary better than what she has now. Real career growth. The kind of thing that does not come along every day.

I want to say something clearly before anything else: this was my choice. Nobody asked me to do it. She did not know it was happening. I did it because I wanted to. That is the whole reason.

I had been thinking about her career for a long time. About where she could go, what she is capable of. I had a project I had built, connections I had made, a friend who trusted my word. So I put it all together quietly. I made the case for her. I spoke about what she can do, what she brings, the kind of person she is.

When the call came and they said yes — I felt something pure. Not pride in what I had done. Just happiness for her. That specific kind of happiness that belongs entirely to someone else, where there is nothing in it for you and you would not want there to be. Just: she is going to get this. Just that.

I wanted us to grow together. Both of us moving forward at the same time. Her career, mine, side by side. That was the picture in my head. That was what I wanted for us.

I messaged her on Instagram.

I told her we had five days. Work from home. Better salary. A real career step. A senior person who already knew about her and was on her side. I wrote it carefully because I wanted her to feel how real it was.

And then I waited.

She did not open it.

Not that day. Not the next. Not the day after. Three days passed. I saw her posting. Active. Going about her life. And the message just sat there.

I wanted to call. I wanted to just say — please read this, it is real, it is good, it is for you.

But she had asked me not to call. So I had a message that was not read and a call I was not allowed to make and five days running out. Nothing in my hands.

She might have thought it was not real. I understand that completely. But I will say it here, in this book that holds every true thing:

**I have never faked anything to her. Not once. Not a single thing.
Everything I have ever done for her has been real. This was real too.**

The five days passed. The offer closed.

After writing this, I unsent the message. Not from anger. Just because it felt wrong to leave something in someone's inbox that they had decided not to open. The door is still open. My friend is still there. I am still here. If she ever wants it, she can ask.

I closed it quietly. The way I close everything.

It is okay. That is the thing I keep coming back to. Somehow, it is okay.

Not because it does not matter. It does. A real opportunity, work from home, better salary, someone already in her corner. It mattered.

But I did not do it to be thanked. I did not do it so she would know. I did it because she deserved it and because I wanted to do something real for her from a distance. Quietly. Even if she never found out.

That is just who I am when it comes to her. I do not think that will ever change.

I hope she finds something even better one day. Something that just comes to her on its own. Something completely hers from the very beginning.

She has everything it takes. She always has.

I wanted us to grow together. I did my part quietly, without telling her, without asking for anything back. That is not something I did for her. That is something I did because of her. There is a difference. And I will always know which one it was.

I closed the laptop. The message was already gone. The watch ticked. The night stayed quiet.

A Page I Didn't Plan To Write

(She asked. She didn't follow through. I am still holding that.)

She once asked me something.

In the middle of everything — the confusion, the distance, all of it — she looked at me and said:

'You tell me what to do. I will do anything you ask.'

I want to sit with that sentence for a moment. I want to give it the space it deserves. Because it is not a small thing. It is not a thing people say casually.

She said: you tell me what to do. I will do anything you ask.

That is one of the most open, most vulnerable things one person can say to another. It is giving over the decision. It is saying — I trust you enough to let you choose. I trust you enough to follow.

And I heard it. I felt it. I held it like something fragile and real.

And then she didn't.

She asked. And then she didn't follow through.

I don't know what happened between the asking and the not following. I don't know if she meant it completely in that moment and then something changed. I don't know if she was scared. I don't know if she said it hoping I would say the right thing and I said the wrong thing. I don't know if she was

testing the ground and found it not solid enough. I genuinely, honestly do not know.

What I know is that she said it. And I know I heard it. And I know some part of me is still holding it — not with anger, not with bitterness, just — holding it. The way you hold something that mattered and never got resolved. Careful with it. Not letting it fall.

That sentence is the closest thing to a door she ever left open for me. And then she closed it before I could walk through.

I don't know if she was faking it. I don't want to believe that. I don't believe that. She is not that person. She is the most caring person I know. So I think she meant it. I think she meant it completely in the moment she said it. And then something — fear maybe, or confusion, or the weight of everything else she was carrying — made it impossible.

That is the most painful version. Because it means we were almost there. It means she saw it too. It means the possibility was real.

And we still ended up here.

Right now, tonight, I am imagining things I know are not going to happen.

I am imagining her showing up at my door. No message first. No planning. Just a knock. Just her there when I open it, saying — come on, let's go get tea.

That is the whole image. That is all of it. Not a grand gesture. Not a declaration. Just a knock and her face and tea.

And I know — with complete certainty, without needing to think about it — that if that happened, if that knock came, I would be the happiest I have ever been. Not because of anything large. Because of the choosing. Because she would have chosen to come. On her own. Without being asked. Without being persuaded. Just chosen.

But she told me I am trouble for her.

She told me not to message first.

So I cannot. I have nothing in my hand. No move available. No message allowed. Just this — sitting in the dark imagining a knock that is not going to come, holding a question she asked me that she did not stay to answer, carrying everything with nowhere to put it except here, in these pages, in this book she has not read yet.

I don't say any of this with anger. I want to be clear about that because it matters. She is still her. Entirely. The cute little panda. The one whose voice made me lose words. The one whose tear made me delete a whole topic from my life forever. The one I drove through the night for. The one I prayed for without making a sound. None of that is different.

I just have nothing left to do. Except the thing I am already doing. Keep going. Keep building. Keep being the person she was afraid I wasn't going to be. Show up for everything. Do the work. Make the false true.

She asked me what to do and I never got to answer properly.

So here it is. Late. Quietly. In a book she hasn't opened yet.

Just be okay. That's all I ever wanted. Just be okay.

I came back to the bed. The watch was still going. I could feel the night beginning to thin.

A Letter

To her,

I don't have many words. You know this about me. I am better at watching than speaking. Better at doing than saying. But I have this.

Every morning I hope it's you. Every single day I show up without being asked, without needing a reason, without waiting to be told. Every crazy thing I do — the sounds on your phone, the wrong answers, all of it — it has never once been about how I look to you. It has always, only, just been to see you smile. That's the whole reason. That's always been the whole reason.

That day you cried — I stopped. Right there, mid sentence, I stopped. And I have never gone back. I will never go back.

That month I left — I cried too. Every day. Not in front of anyone. Not in a way you would have seen. But I cried. I want you to know that. Because you said you learned to live without me, and I need you to know that I never learned. I tried. I failed every single day.

Every 15 minutes. Every morning where I hoped and it wasn't you. Every separate payment at the tea shop. Every moment I stepped back when everything in me wanted to step forward. Every night I drove through 2am because going home alone was not survivable. Every word of this book

written in the dark outside a shop with tea going cold beside me. It was all for you. Every single second of all of it.

Tik. Tik. Tik. I hear that watch and I think of you. I will always think of you.

You once asked me — tell me what to do, I will do anything you ask. I never answered that properly. So here it is, late and quietly: just be happy. That is the whole answer. Just be okay. That is all I have ever wanted from you.

That night you said you wanted to cry — I couldn't breathe. I bought a litre of water and drank it standing up. I drove through the night with friends who knew something was wrong and did not ask. I went to a temple at dawn and I asked inside, without sound, for your problem to be solved. Not for myself. For you. Because I was not there and that was the only way I could reach you.

From my side — it has always been you. Only you. Whatever the future becomes, whatever shape things take, whatever either of us builds — from my side, that has never been in question. Not for a single day of any of this.

I don't need much. I'm not asking for anything.

I just want you to know it's real. All of it. Every chapter. Every 3am. Every tear and smile at the same time. Every word of this. Every single bit of it is real.

Yours,

The one who checked your snap every 15 minutes and called it surviving.

A Note Before You Close This

You will never read this. Not today. Not yet.

This whole book — every chapter, every word, every honest embarrassing true thing in here — none of it has reached you yet. It is still waiting. It will keep waiting for as long as it needs to.

This book is not finished. It will never really be finished. Every time something happens — every time you make me laugh, every time you scold me in a voice note, every time I check my phone at 3am and hope it's you, every time I see something and think she would like that — something new gets added. This book grows with every chapter of us. It always will. For as long as you are my moon, this book keeps going.

But one day — the day you come back like before, the day things are just us again the way they are supposed to be — I will send you all of it.

Every chapter. Every word. Every crazy thing I did just to make you smile. Every 3am thought. Every 15-minute snap check. Every time I couldn't speak because your voice was just too much. Every night I drove through 2am because I couldn't go home alone with it. The tea outside the shop. The temple at dawn. The prayer that made no sound. All of it. Waiting here for that one day.

That is the day you find out.

Until then, it just lives here. With me. The most honest thing I have ever written. Quietly waiting for the right moment to reach you.

I am always waiting for her. Always hoping she will come back. I have not stopped and I will not stop.

Nights feel incomplete without her. Not uncomfortable — incomplete. Like a sentence that ends before it finishes saying what it meant. I get through them. I wake up. But that specific quality of complete that only she brings — it is not there. And I notice it every night.

I feel incomplete without her. Not broken. Not unable to function. Just — incomplete. Like something real is missing from the shape of things.

She thinks I will forget her after some time. I understand why she thinks that. Most people move on. Time passes. Feelings fade.

But she does not know me the way I know myself. I can forget many things. I have forgotten many things. But I cannot forget her. If anything, it would be easier to forget myself than to forget her. She is more fixed in me than I am.

Relationships are meant to be fulfilled. Not left. Not run from. Meant to be stayed in, built carefully, seen all the way through.

That is what I believe. That is what I have always believed. And I still believe it. Even now. Even here.

It will reach you.

— End —

For my Moon. She already knows.

Tik. Tik. Tik.



*This is not a love story.
Love stories have endings.
This one is still waiting.*

*One night. One watch.
Thirty-one thoughts.
One name. Always.*

Tik. Tik. Tik.

Tik. Tik. Tik.
a love that refused to be silent

for my Moon — she already knows